FOCUS ON READING COMPREHENSION & VOCABULARY

English Revision ACON-B 2026 for the English Written Test 01

01) READ the passage carefully, then **CIRCLE THE CORRECT ANSWER** for each question.

Maritime Communication and Leadership

On any ship's bridge, the gravity of each uttered word is impossible to overstate, for communication is the central nervous system of navigation and safety. The bridge environment is a highly dynamic space where multiple streams of information converge simultaneously—radar returns, radio calls, engine readouts, visual observations, and time-critical instructions. In such a setting, misinterpretations can cascade into operational hazards with alarming speed, making verbal precision not merely desirable but indispensable. A single ambiguous command—whether caused by flawed phrasing, a thick accent, crew fatigue, or ambient noise from machinery and alarms—can trigger hesitation or inconsistent actions among the watch team. These lapses may seem trivial in isolation but can escalate quickly when a vessel navigates congested shipping lanes, executes delicate close-quarters maneuvers, or encounters rapidly deteriorating weather conditions. For these reasons, bridge communication must be executed with unwavering clarity, both in form and in intent, ensuring that every message transmitted is understood exactly as intended.

Contrary to popular cinematic portrayals of maritime authority—scenes where captains shout orders heroically above roaring waves—effective bridge discipline has little to do with raising one's voice. In the professional maritime sphere, leadership manifests more prominently through structured, deliberate, and methodical communication rather than sheer volume. Officers who habitually resort to shouting often signal insecurity, emotional instability, or lack of procedural knowledge rather than operational competence. What truly distinguishes a proficient bridge team is its collective ability to communicate succinctly under pressure, maintain composure during unexpected developments, and prioritize precision over theatrics. In high-stakes environments, a calm voice and structured sentence can be more powerful than the loudest shout, shaping a disciplined operational culture grounded in clarity and professionalism.

Central to achieving this communicative precision is the adoption of the Standard Marine Communication Phrases (SMCP), a carefully codified lexicon developed by the IMO to eliminate ambiguity and enhance safety across multinational crews. As modern shipping relies heavily on diverse teams representing dozens of linguistic backgrounds, SMCP provides a universal linguistic framework that standardizes vocabulary related to navigation, emergency response, distress situations, and routine shipboard operations. Through structured phrases such as "I require assistance," "Stand by," or "Alter course to port," crews avoid idiomatic expressions or culturally dependent language that may confuse non-native speakers. In practical terms, SMCP allows an OOW from Brazil to seamlessly coordinate with a helmsman from India, an engineer from the Philippines, or a pilot from Europe—all using harmonized terminology that transcends cultural and phonetic differences. Its adoption directly enhances situational awareness and reduces the margin for communicative error.

Complementing the standardized vocabulary of SMCP is the indispensable technique of closed-loop communication, a best-practice procedure requiring the receiver of an order to repeat it verbatim before taking action. This confirmation process serves as a critical safety barrier, abolishing assumptions and ensuring alignment between intention and execution. By repeating instructions such as "Alter course to 085 degrees," the helmsman confirms the command and gives the officer a last chance to detect misunderstandings before the maneuver occurs. The loop creates a micro-moment of verification—a buffer that prevents human error from quietly infiltrating the sequence of operations. When executed properly, closed-loop communication transforms potential uncertainty into operational confidence, strengthening teamwork and reinforcing accountability on the bridge.

During high-pressure situations such as near-misses, equipment malfunctions, unexpected traffic encounters, or rapidly shifting sea states, the tone of communication becomes just as crucial as its content. Research in human-factors psychology consistently reveals that calm, measured speech stabilizes team performance by regulating cognitive load and reducing stress responses. A composed voice can cut through panic, temper impulsive reactions, and re-anchor the team's mental focus on the immediate task. Calm leadership does not imply passivity; rather, it represents an intentional act of emotional regulation, allowing officers to exert authority without coercion. By projecting steadiness during chaos, a leader creates a psychological buffer that supports sound judgment and coordinated action.

Experienced masters often describe the bridge not merely as a workspace but as a psychological ecosystem, one in which emotional contagion occurs rapidly and subconsciously. When a captain radiates panic—through tone, body language, or rushed speech—the entire bridge team absorbs and amplifies that anxiety, compromising situational awareness and impairing decision-making. Conversely, when an officer communicates with deliberate serenity, that demeanor reshapes the cognitive atmosphere, promoting clarity of thought and enabling team members to process complex information more accurately. This psychological dynamic explains why the most respected bridge leaders command not with volume but with presence, restraint, and linguistic precision. They understand that emotional stability is a strategic instrument of maritime safety.

Modern maritime operations—driven by automation, sophisticated traffic systems, cybersecurity vulnerabilities, digital sensors, and multinational crews—have elevated communication standards to unprecedented levels. Vessels today navigate in a world in which AIS clutter, VTS directives, electronic chart updates, digital alarms, and environmental regulations converge simultaneously, demanding rapid comprehension and flawless coordination. This multifaceted operational complexity makes structured communication not merely efficient but existentially important. One unclear instruction, one misheard message, or one incomplete report has the potential to disrupt workflow, misalign priorities, or generate conflicting actions between departments. As ships become more technologically advanced, the human responsibility for precise communication becomes even more essential.

Ultimately, the defining trait of competent maritime leadership is the ability to remain verbally disciplined even amid uncertainty. At sea, clarity is not a courtesy; it is a survival tool. Leaders who speak calmly yet assertively maintain team cohesion and set a standard of professionalism that the entire bridge naturally emulates. They demonstrate that true authority is exercised through focus, not force, through articulation, not aggression. In the modern bridge environment, where the margin for error is increasingly slim, lives and cargo are safeguarded not by the loudest voice but by the clearest one. Effective communication is, therefore, both a practical skill and a moral responsibility for anyone entrusted with command.

Reading Comprehension and Vocabulary Questions:

1.1) According to Paragraph 1, why is verbal precision considered indispensable on the bridge?

a) Because it allows officers to communicate more politely.
b) Because misinterpreted commands can escalate into dangerous situations.
c) Because most crew members are unfamiliar with navigational equipment.
d) Because ships today rely almost entirely on radio communication.
e) Because maritime law requires officers to use scripted phrases at all times.

1.2) What is the author's main criticism of shouting as a leadership tool on the bridge?

a) It works only during emergency operations.
b) It makes communication slower and less accurate.
c) It reflects insecurity rather than professional competence.
d) It is prohibited under SMCP regulations.
e) It distracts engineers in the engine room.

1.3) The purpose of SMCP, as described in Paragraph 3, is to:

a) Enforce strict discipline among multinational crews.
b) Create a universal set of phrases to avoid ambiguity.
c) Standard radio frequencies across regions.
d) Replace all forms of visual signaling.
e) Ensure that only native English speakers can give commands.

1.4) Closed-loop communication improves safety primarily by:

a) Increasing the speed of verbal interaction.
b) Allowing officers to give multiple orders simultaneously.
c) Ensuring that orders are repeated for verification.
d) Eliminating the need for emergency drills.
e) Allowing crew members to question senior officers freely.

1.5) In Paragraph 5, the author suggests that calm speech during emergencies:

a) Slows down decision-making.
b) Weakens the officer's authority.
c) Tends to confuse less experienced sailors.
d) Stabilizes the team's performance and focus.
e) Should only be used after the crisis has ended.

1.6) Paragraph 6 introduces the bridge as a "psychological ecosystem" to illustrate that:

a) Emotional states spread quickly among team members.
b) The bridge is an uncomfortable place to work.
c) Strict silence is required during stressful operations.
d) Officers must use psychological tests when selecting crew.
e) Bridges should be redesigned with better ergonomic layouts.

1.7) Which of the following best summarizes the challenge described in Paragraph 7?

a) Modern ships rely too heavily on manual navigation techniques.
b) Increased technological complexity demands clearer communication.
c) Automation has reduced the importance of human operators.
d) Most crews resist using SMCP in advanced vessels.
e) Environmental regulations have eliminated the need for radio calls.

1.8) According to Paragraph 8, effective maritime leadership is based primarily on:

a) Physical strength and quick reactions.
b) Strict enforcement of hierarchical rules.
c) The ability to give long, detailed speeches.
d) Calm, precise, and assertive communication.
e) Memorizing all international regulations.

1.9) Which statement reflects the author's view of communication errors on the modern bridge?

a) They are inevitable and rarely harmful.
b) They occur only among inexperienced officers.
c) They can disrupt workflows in complex operational environments.
d) They are easily corrected by electronic devices.
e) They usually result from outdated SMCP vocabulary.

1.10) Across the passage, the author consistently argues that:

a) Technology will soon eliminate the need for verbal commands.
b) Loud commands increase team cohesion.
c) Precision and emotional composure are central to safe bridge communication.
d) Maritime English should be replaced with automated messaging.
e) Only native speakers can lead effectively.

FOCUS ON GRAMMAR

02) COMPLETE the radio exchange below by **FILLING** in each blank (1–10) with the correct phrase from the Word Bank. Each phrase is used once only and **MUST BE INSERTED** exactly as it appears. **DO NOT ADD** or **MODIFY.**

Word Bank (Use each once)					
A. reduce to Slow Ahead	B. altering course	C. keep your course and speed	J. alter		
D. Proceed with caution	I. advise	E. Understood	F. confirm	G. standing on	H. reducing

MV Atlantic Spirit:
"Container vessel on my port bow, this is MV Atlantic Spirit. You are ______________________ (2.1) into my track. I intend to _____________________ (2.2) to starboard and reduce speed to **Half Ahead**. What are your intentions? _____________________________ (2.3). Over."

Container Vessel:
"MV Atlantic Spirit, this is Ocean Runner. _________________________ (2.4) your message. I am _______________________ (2.5) my course to port to increase CPA. My speed will _______________ (2.6) for the next five minutes.

You are ____ (2.7) to maintain a safe distance.
Please ____ (2.8) your manoeuvre. Over."

MV Atlantic Spirit:
"Ocean Runner, MV Atlantic Spirit. ________________ (2.9). I will keep clear of you and _________ _______________________(2.10) with caution. Out."

03) WRITE what each abbreviation stands for:

a) AIS: ____

b) ETA: ____

c) CPA: ____

d) VHF: ____

e) GMDSS: ____

04) WRITE the correct form of the word in **CAPITALS** given in brackets.

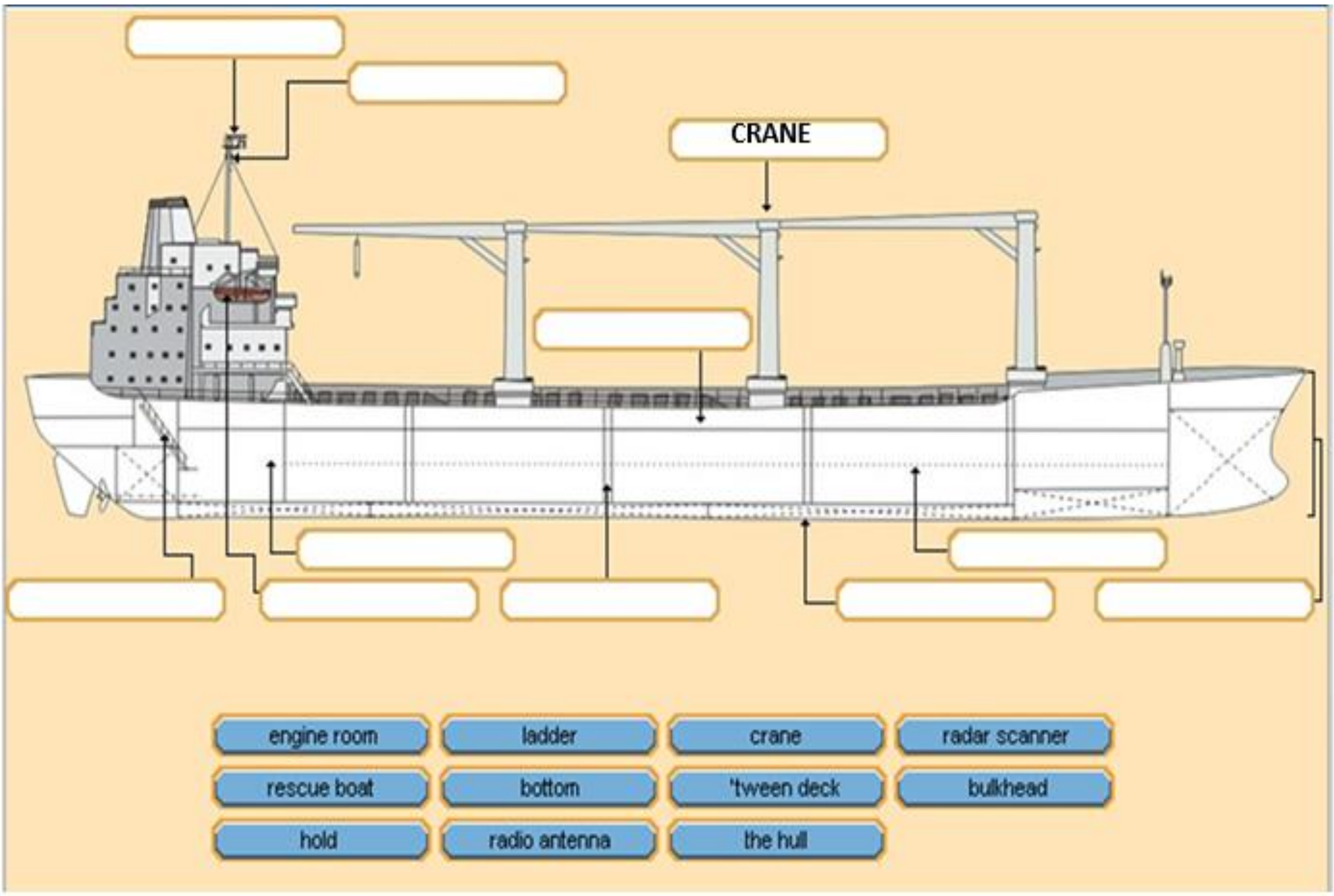
Life on the bridge demands constant (4.1) __________________________ (ATTEND) from every officer, especially during restricted-visibility (4.2) __________________________ (OPERATE). The Master often emphasizes that even minor (4.3) _________________________ (INACCURATE) in judgment can lead to unsafe situations, particularly when the vessel is approaching a (4.4) ____________________________ (SEPARATE) traffic lane.

Before sailing, Deck Officers carry out a full (4.5) ________________________ (EXAMINE) of the navigational equipment to ensure all systems are (4.6) _________________________ (RELY) and compliant with international regulations. The increased (4.7) ________________________ (COMPLEX) of modern bridges means that officers must maintain high levels of (4.8) _________________________ (COMPETENT), professionalism, and situational awareness.

Although technology assists navigation, (4.9) ____________________ (JUDGE) remains essential; otherwise, officers may misinterpret data and make (4.10) _________________________ (RISK) decisions under pressure.

FOCUS ON VOCABULARY

05) Write the correct word related to each circle below: **One word will not be used!**



06) WRITE the following cases to the correct code: **Mayday, Pan-Pan, Securité.**

6.1) A man overboard with immediate danger to life. ___________________________

6.2) An urgent medical case onboard requiring assistance. ____________________

6.3) A warning of approaching severe weather in the area. ____________________

6.4) Mechanical failure that does not immediately threaten safety. ______________

6.5) Navigation hazard caused by a derelict vessel. ____________________________

07) Match the definitions below with the correct word.

7.1) Fairway speed ( ) a vessel's reduced speed in circumstances where it may....

7.2) Full speed ( ) the speed of a vessel, allowing time for effective action to be..

7.3) Search speed ( ) the speed of searching vessels directed by the OSC.

7.4) Boarding speed ( ) the mandatory speed in a fairway.

7.5) Transit speed ( ) the highest possible speed of a vessel.

7.6) Safe speed ( ) the speed of a vessel adjusted to that of a pilot boat at.....

7.7) Manoeuvring speed ( ) here: the speed of a vessel required for passage through a ..

08) Scenario: "You are the OOW on a bulk carrier approaching a narrow channel in heavy traffic. You need to exchange information with nearby vessels and a VTS station using IMO Standard Marine Communication Phrases."

Word Bank (Use each phrase once):

Stand by on VHF Channel 16   My course is __ degrees   Crossing my vessel from port   My speed is ___ knots   Keep well clear of my vessel   Attention   Say again   I require tug assistance   Crossing my vessel from port   Risk of collision exists   What is your position?

Fill in the blanks with the correct SMCP phrase from the word bank.

8.1) "________________________________, please. I did not understand your last transmission."

8.2) "_____________________________, you are approaching the narrow channel from the west."

8.3) "____, my present heading is 270."

8.4) "____, I am currently making 15."

8.5) "_____________________________________, you are on a collision course with my vessel."

8.6) "____ immediately to avoid incident."

8.7) "____, I am unable to steer due to rudder failure."

8.8) "____, I repeat: alter course to starboard."

8.9) "____? I cannot see you on the radar."

8.10) "_______________________________ for further instructions before entering the channel."

FOCUS ON WRITING

09) WRITE a complete **MAYDAY message** using only **IMO Standard Marine Communication Phrases (SMCP)**. **FOLLOW** the exact order required:

MAYDAY – Identification – Position – Nature of Distress – Assistance Required – Persons on Board – Additional Information – OVER.

SCENARIO (USE EXACTLY AS WRITTEN):

You are the **Master of M/V ATLANTIC SPIRIT**, callsign **PQCX**, IMO number **9485631**.
At **0405 UTC**, your vessel collides with a drifting steel barge.
Your present position is **34°15.6' N – 057°42.3' W**.
The collision caused a **2-meter breach in the hull below the waterline on the starboard side, and the vessel is taking on water rapidly**.
The **engine room is flooding**, pumps cannot cope, and **the ship is in danger of sinking**.
You require **immediate assistance**.
There are **22 persons on board**.

Temporary damage control has begun, but the situation remains **critical**, and the **liferafts are ready for possible abandonment**.

WRITE the full MAYDAY message as you would transmit by VHF.

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ANSWER KEY WITH JUSTIFICATIONS

01) Reading Comprehension

1.1) B Because misinterpreted commands can escalate into dangerous situations.

Justification: O primeiro parágrafo afirma que comandos mal interpretados podem gerar hesitação, ações inconsistentes e rapidamente evoluir para riscos operacionais.

1.2) C It reflects insecurity rather than professional competence.

Justification: O texto afirma que oficiais que gritam frequentemente demonstram insegurança, instabilidade emocional ou falta de conhecimento procedimental.

1.3) B Create a universal set of phrases to avoid ambiguity.

Justification: O SMCP foi desenvolvido pela IMO para eliminar ambiguidades e padronizar a comunicação entre tripulações multinacionais.

1.4) C Ensuring that orders are repeated for verification.

Justification: Closed-loop communication exige que a ordem seja repetida antes da execução para confirmar que foi entendida corretamente.

1.5) D Stabilizes the team's performance and focus.

Justification: O texto cita estudos de fatores humanos mostrando que uma voz calma reduz o estresse e melhora o desempenho da equipe.

1.6) A Emotional states spread quickly among team members.

Justification: O autor utiliza a expressão "psychological ecosystem" para explicar que emoções, especialmente o pânico, se espalham rapidamente pela equipe.

1.7) B Increased technological complexity demands clearer communication.

Justification: Quanto mais avançada a tecnologia embarcada, maior é a necessidade de comunicação estruturada e precisa.

1.8) D Calm, precise, and assertive communication.

Justification: O último parágrafo conclui que a verdadeira liderança marítima se baseia na clareza, serenidade e assertividade.

1.9) C They can disrupt workflows in complex operational environments.

Justification: O texto afirma que uma única mensagem incorreta pode desalinhar prioridades e comprometer operações.

1.10) C Precision and emotional composure are central to safe bridge communication.

Justification: Esta é justamente a tese defendida ao longo de todo o texto.

02) Grammar

2.1 crossing my vessel from port

2.2 alter

2.3 Advise

2.4 confirm

2.5 altering course

2.6 reducing

2.7 keep your course and speed

2.8 confirm

(Embora "confirm" apareça duas vezes na prova, o Word Bank apresenta apenas uma ocorrência, indicando um pequeno erro de elaboração da questão.)

2.9 Understood

2.10 Proceed with caution

03) Abbreviations

a) AIS **Automatic Identification System**

b) ETA **Estimated Time of Arrival**

c) CPA **Closest Point of Approach**

d) VHF **Very High Frequency**

e) GMDSS **Global Maritime Distress and Safety System**

04) Word Formation

4.1 attention

4.2 operations

4.3 inaccuracies

4.4 separation (Traffic Separation Scheme)

4.5 examination

4.6 reliable

4.7 complexity

4.8 competence

4.9 judgment

4.10 risky

06)

6.1 MAYDAY *(Immediate danger to life.)*

6.2 PAN-PAN *(Urgent medical assistance.)*

6.3 SECURITÉ *(Safety warning.)*

6.4 PAN-PAN *(Urgent but not immediately life-threatening.)*

6.5 SECURITÉ *(Navigation hazard.)*

07)

7.1 Fairway speed

Mandatory speed in a fairway.

7.2 Full speed

The highest possible speed of a vessel.

7.3 Search speed

The speed of searching vessels directed by the OSC.

7.4 Boarding speed

The speed of a vessel adjusted to that of a pilot boat.

7.5 Transit speed

The speed required for passage through a route.

7.6 Safe speed

The speed allowing effective action to avoid collision.

7.7 Manoeuvring speed

A vessel's reduced speed allowing safe manoeuvring.

08)

8.1 Say again

8.2 Attention

8.3 My course is 270 degrees

8.4 My speed is 15 knots

8.5 Risk of collision exists

8.6 Keep well clear of my vessel

8.7 I require tug assistance

8.8 Crossing my vessel from port

8.9 What is your position?

8.10 Stand by on VHF Channel 16

09) Model MAYDAY Message

MAYDAY, MAYDAY, MAYDAY

This is **M/V ATLANTIC SPIRIT**, callsign **PQCX**, IMO number **9485631**.

My position is **34 degrees 15.6 minutes North, 057 degrees 42.3 minutes West**.

I have collided with a drifting steel barge.

My vessel has a **2-meter breach below the waterline on the starboard side**. The engine room is flooding. Pumps cannot cope. The vessel is taking on water rapidly and is in danger of sinking.

I require immediate assistance.

There are **22 persons on board.**

Temporary damage control is in progress. Liferafts are ready for possible abandonment.

OVER.